



(LEFT) THE DALAI LAMA IN TAWANG; KRISHNA WITH HIS CHINESE COUNTERPART YANG



during his visit to the US last month. But the Chinese were proved wrong.

That New Delhi wanted to take the plunge was also evident as it ignored the advice from its 'strategic partner', the US, to reschedule the visit.

But the Government took a calculated risk, as this was also a crucial moment to flex India's diplomatic muscle, which had been missing, especially in India's China policy. Besides, it also sends a message to the world that India can take on a country like China on matters of national interest.

The Dalai Lama had initially indicated that he wanted to visit Arunachal Pradesh last year but was advised by the Government to defer it, given that the two sides were exchanging high-level visits and India didn't want friction. Sources say the turning point came when Beijing's provocations became alarming.

“We cannot tell the Dalai Lama not to go to Arunachal Pradesh. They should not read much into it. We want cordial relations with China.”

S.M. KRISHNA
External Affairs Minister

The number of intrusions on the boundary increased. Besides, a Chinese think tank backed by the Government suggested that China should break India into 36 parts. India was also concerted at China's persistent anti-India stand at multilateral fora. Beijing's aggressive statements opposing the visit of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to Arunachal Pra-

desh led the UPA Government to react, as there was a growing criticism within the country that the Government was soft on China "We were being criticised for being soft. We want to have good ties with China but there is a limit to our patience," explained a key government functionary.

But even in the face of provocation from its neighbour, New Delhi exercised restraint and tried to defuse the crisis through diplomatic means, but failed. Last month, as tensions grew, New Delhi quietly sent a message through its envoy S. Jaishankar to the Chinese that faced with a vocal Chinese stand against the PM's visit to Arunachal Pradesh, India would have no choice but to react. But instead of toning down its

criticism, the Chinese upped the ante.

While there are stories in China's official media warning India of the consequences like the 1962 war, it is unlikely that China will risk that. Because in Circa 2009, India is not a Third World boarder but a robust power with nuclear weapons. Besides, even a limited border war may pull international powers to the region which China will not want. Another factor is that the Chinese leadership may not like to jeopardise the \$52-billion trade that has created economic interdependence between the two countries. While India needs to stay the course, it should resist any pressure from China to change India's border interlocutor M.K. Narayanan, which Beijing wants, as it is frustrated with the slow pace of boundary talks. The Government has demonstrated a spine in its China policy, and it should now stay firm on it. ■